

Amendment No. 1 to HB0326

White
Signature of Sponsor

AMEND Senate Bill No. 631

House Bill No. 326*

by deleting all language after the caption and substituting:

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra Olivia Smithson, SSSF, well known as Sister Sandra, was an educator, visionary, and a pioneering advocate for impoverished and underprivileged children, and particularly Black and Latino children, through education; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra was born March 3, 1926, in Nashville as the sixth of ten children to her parents, the late Mr. John Lee and Mrs. Lou Ora Berry Smithson; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra grew up in North Nashville near St. Vincent de Paul Church and attended St. Vincent de Paul Church school, which was founded by St. Katherine Drexel, who was an heiress and who used her fortune to establish schools to educate Black and Native American children; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra, as the first student ever to enroll at St. Vincent de Paul School, drew inspiration from the example of St. Katherine Drexel; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra received her postsecondary education at Xavier University in New Orleans, the only historically Black Catholic college in America, and later received a teaching fellowship at Fisk University to work toward a Master's degree in literature; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra entered religious life in 1954 as a member of the School Sisters of St. Francis (SSSF) order after having been rejected by other orders because of her race; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra thereafter worked as a member of her religious order for the next 67 years across the Western Hemisphere as an educator in Costa Rica; Chicago, Illinois;

Milwaukee, Wisconsin; and Honduras, and had an outsized influence on the lives of all children whom she nurtured and educated; and

WHEREAS, upon her return to her native Nashville, Sister Sandra in 1992 founded Project Reflect, a nonprofit organization whose mission is to "transform urban America through education and education reform"; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra advocated for and influenced the passage of seminal charter school legislation in the Tennessee General Assembly and founded the first charter school, Smithson Craighead Academy, in Middle Tennessee in 2003; and

WHEREAS, Smithson Craighead Academy continues to this day to serve the educational and other needs of primarily Black and Latino children from low-income families; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra's concentration, dedication, and humor on behalf of urban children, especially those from a culture of poverty, helped them gain the academic skills and character formation to become responsible, effective architects of their own lives; and

WHEREAS, Sister Sandra authored and co-authored a number of books, including *Alegro and the Very Imperfect Poodle*, *From Out of the Shadows*, *Night Bird in Solitary Song*, and *To Be the Bridge* to further her mission; now, therefore,

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 15, Chapter 2, is amended by adding the following as a new section:

March 3 of every year is observed as "Sister Sandra Smithson Day," to honor the immeasurable effect Sister Sandra had on this state and the lives of its children in need through the power of improved educational opportunities and the founding of Nashville's first charter school. This day is not a legal holiday as defined in § 15-1-101.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect upon becoming a law, the public welfare requiring it.